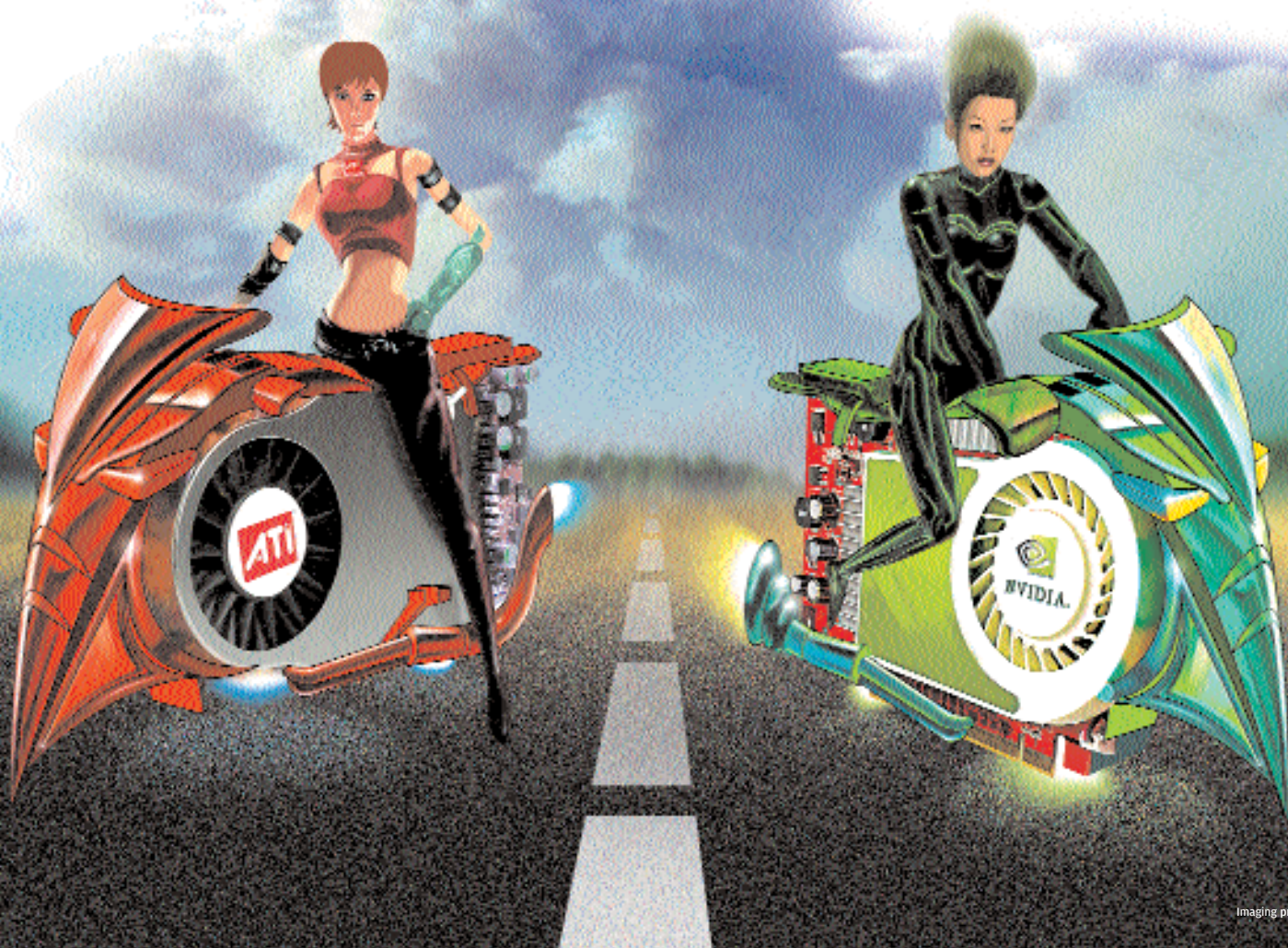




imaging pradipt ingale

# Blazing Angels

**Graphics cards bring the flesh and the flash into gaming, and are an essential part of a good multimedia PC. There's one to suit each requirement, every budget. So here are 65 graphics cards—fresh and hot from our test labs!**

**Michael Browne**

**T**he graphics card industry is one of the fastest evolving amongst all PC hardware segments. Spitting out new products and allied technologies every six months or so, no other component has so short a life cycle as a graphics card.

Just think about it—Pentium 4 CPUs have been around since 2001, and have only now been replaced by the Core 2 Duo series. In contrast, NVIDIA's GeForce FX series of graphics cards were introduced in 2003, and were already outdated in late 2004, being replaced by the 6xxx series—just one example of how quickly things change in the world of the Graphics Processing Unit.

The reason for this fast turnover is, in part, the game developers, who are constantly pushing the envelopes of realism in the drive for immersive 3D gaming. Games, as we all know, are amongst the most demanding applications, and developers seem to swear by the “Let me bring this card to its knees” slogan. Every six months we see some game title that beats the stuffing out of the fastest cards available, and forces manufacturers back to the drawing board!

This year was a record of sorts for us. We received 65 graphics cards for the test, and in stark contrast with previous years, there was an abundance of cards based on high-end chipsets. This reconfirms the fact that the gaming hardware industry in India is booming, and gamers are willing to splurge. We've also heard the ringing of the death-knell for the AGP standard, and